

Chapter 2

Tanya could not say for how long heavy artillery battered the fortress, only kept at bay through the wit and skill of the Alliance. They were, after all, the strongest in the land, the bravest and the ones fighting for the very noblest cause. The words poured over Tanya's head from multiple mouths until she could take no more and curled up on her narrow bed, paws clamped over her eyes. They left her alone then, the many mouths, but without telling her, one last time, that The True Alliance was there to save her. She should be thankful to them for rescuing her from the clutches of a corrupt church. They were doing good in the world – she should remember that and be grateful for it. But that was only what she was told. If she was honest with herself, they could have told her anything at that time and she would have had no choice but to believe it.

They moved her to a dormitory style bedroom after a total of six meals had been brought to her. Although she had counted the meals, there was no distinction between them that could have allowed her to tell the time of day. Not that it mattered all that much. Tanya found it hard to care, mind still reeling from the knowledge that she had been one of the godlike ones. She had committed so many cruelties.

Her best friend – or not anymore – stood guard at the door, eyes ever watchful and reserved. She kept her paw close to her blade, fingers occasionally twitching as if they itched to wrap themselves around the hilt.

From the time Tanya had entered the otherwise empty dormitory with rickety, wooden-framed beds, Reline had not once left her post. She didn't know how many hours had passed with no way to see whether it was dark or light outside, but the wolf had a tired sway to her stance. She constantly drooped to one side and jerked herself upright again as if trying to keep herself upright.

"I have been assigned as your guard. My post shall not be left unattended."

Reline's muzzle held a distinct look of displeasure and Tanya stepped back. Her ears dropped down to her skull as she shook her head, thinking about extending a paw to her old friend but not finding she had the heart to reach out. What was the point? Reline no longer cared for her – that much was clear.

"I thought Wenton was supposed to be guarding me?" Tanya pointed to the door. "Isn't he just on the other side of the door?"

Reline flinched.

"That does not mean I may shirk my duty."

Tanya sighed.

"So, you're just going to stay up all night then? How do you think that's going to work for you? You're dead on your paws."

"Am not!"

Tanya rolled her eyes.

“Have it your way. I’m going to sleep. Do the same if you decide to...or not. Doesn’t seem that you’re going to listen to me either way so it doesn’t matter.”

The word tumbled off her tongue over one another and she knew she was rambling like an imbecile. A small part of her, tucked away deep inside, still hoped that Reline would have a change of heart. She hadn’t been around the wolf at the Alliance for very long, after all. Maybe she would learn that Tanya was not as bad as she thought. She had no memory of these supposed heinous acts she’d committed. She felt the same as ever. Could it be so despicable? Wasn’t she being used against her will?

Tanya shook her head against the onslaught of thoughts. Those would have to be kept for another day. Even though she didn’t know if it was day or night still.

Throwing herself back on the random bed she’d chosen, she drew a better-kept blanket up to her chest and reached over to blow out the flame in the small lantern she had been permitted. It did not light up much of the room but it did her well enough, casting a circle into flickering illumination. The last thing she saw before the dormitory was plunged into blackness was Reline’s scowling muzzle, half-illuminated by a dying flame.

The wax fizzled.

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“Get up.”

Tanya blinked herself awake, wishing, not for the first time, that she was in her own bed, as uncomfortable as she remembered it to be. She stretched and yawned, looking up at the wolf she stood with her arms crossed over her chest and toe tapping. There were lines below her bloodshot eyes, visible through the thinner, grey fur on her muzzle. The wolf looked like she hadn’t slept in weeks.

“Is it morning?”

Tanya sat up and rubbed her muzzle, hair a roughened up mess from tossing and turning all night. A spot between her shoulder blades ached as if she’d been sleeping on a lump all night. She poked the straw mattress dubiously with one probing fingertip. Maybe she had.

Reline’s lips twitched.

“As good as morning. Get up.”

“All right, all right, have some patience. Sheesh. What crawled into your bonnet and died?”

The words spilled from her lips, familiar from a past life, before she could stop them. Clapping a paw over her muzzle, her eyes widened and she fought down a giggle. Had she really said that? Again? Reline had made her promise not to make the quip after she’d muttered it one too many times. The same thing over and over again got old quick, she’d said

– have some variety, Tanya! She shot Reline a look, expecting to be playfully told off, and her heart sank when she saw that the wolf’s expression was as stony as ever.

“I see no humour in that. I will wait for you outside. There is water and cloth at the far end.”

She jerked her head in the general direction of supplies with which Tanya could use to freshen up.

“What about a change of clothes?”

Reline laughed and left the room, shaking her head. Tanya supposed it was a little too much to ask for but she could only hope. Hers were starting to smell and she wrinkled her nose as she washed her muzzle with a sodden rag, wiping sleep from her eyes.

Joining Reline at the door, she chanced a smile and a small wave at Wenton. The ox snorted and stared straight ahead down a long, narrow corridor that rose sharply on an incline. Muscle bulged through his jerkin and the vixen looked away. If it came to a tussle, she didn’t stand a hope against the ox. She’d have to be clever if she wanted to escape. For what life did she have with the Alliance and a friend who did not even want to remember she existed?

As if done with Tanya, Reline strode down the corridor without a second thought, leaving the vixen to catch up after some encouragement from Wenton – one look was enough.

Sighing, Tanya trotted to catch up with Reline. The wolf only walked more quickly as if wanting to keep some distance between her and the fox. Tanya’s lips turned down and she plodded along behind with a sullen, heavy tread.

Her stomach rumbled, reminding her that she had not eaten since...well, not since she had been held in that tiny room. Not since she’d been moved to the dormitory. She nipped her lip and tried not to think of food. Surely the others were hungry too? They had to be.

“Where are we going?” She demanded crassly, paws swinging at her sides.

Reline didn’t look back as she replied.

“Well, if we must look after you, we’re not going to miss our training sessions.” Reline looked at the fox like she had lost her mind. “You are not that important to us, fox.”

Tanya winced.

“You know my name.”

“That doesn’t mean I have to use it.”

Tanya looked pleadingly to the ox as her stomach growled viciously.

“Aren’t we even going to stop to break our fast? Food? There were meals brought in my other room.”

Reline huffed and tucked a strand of hair back behind her ear from where it had curled into her eye.

“Training fasted is better preparation for battle.”

Tanya took that as confirmation that she would not be getting breakfast anytime soon.

“Move along there,” Wenton grunted, prodding her in the small of her back with a surprisingly gentle paw. “Don’t lag behind.”

“Or what?” She snapped, hunger pulling her to the limits of what patience she had.

Wenton shrugged, rolling his massive shoulders forward.

“I could bind and gag you and leave you back in the dormitory. Or on the edge of the training grounds for everyone to have a good laugh at. Either way matters little to me if it gets you to shut that mouth of yours.”

Tanya scoffed and rolled her eyes, her old rebellious attitude flaring to the surface. There seemed to be hardly any reason to obey and her tongue moved before her mind caught up with her words.

“Would you dare?”

He curled his paw around her shoulder, chilling her to the bone. Her breath quickened, chest rising and falling rapidly as her heart raced quicker than a runaway horse. Wenton put his muzzle close to her ear, hot, putrid breath ruffling her fur.

“Would you like to find out?”

There wasn’t much a lone vixen could say to that that was not already obvious.

Grumbling, Tanya shrugged him off with as much bravado as she could manage, quickening her stride to walk at Reline’s heels. Watching training – what would that entail? Ruffians hitting each other with swords? Jorro had never been particularly good at sword fighting so she had little previous experience to go on – didn’t sound enthralling. Yet it had to be better than the ox’s dull threats.

They didn’t seem to care much about Tanya learning her way around the keep and its network of underground tunnels. It was a rat’s nest anyway, a complete and utter maze, so there was no way she would find her way about without noting anything down. The vixen scowled. Getting out of there was looking to be a greater and greater impossibility with every passing moment.

Eventually, not meeting a single soul along the way, the strange trio stepped into bright sunlight. Tanya blinked up at a blue sky scattered with fluffy clouds and stretched out her arms to either side of her body. Sunshine had never felt so good on her fur! She turned in a slow circle, soaking it in, as Wenton eyed her warily, no movement passing unchecked.

The training grounds were encircled by wooden palisades, rising to sharp points where natural bark was stripped away. It was split into two, one half with a dip in the middle that Tanya thought would allow trainees to practice fighting from different levels and vantage points, and the other with a flat, perfectly smooth earthen surface. It seemed that the majority of the Alliance took themselves to the training grounds on a morning, explaining why the interior of the keep was so deserted, as there were too many present for the eye to count, moving swiftly between exercises and drills.

Whereas some chose to train solely with weapons, pairing and grouping up to engage in mock skirmishes, others devoted time to strength and endurance training. One strange pine marten with striking cream streaks across his muzzle, carried a large rock back and forth across the training pit, sweat pouring from his brow and soaking his fur. His arms shook with the strength it took to lug the heavy rock back and forth, placing it down and picking it up again at each end of the pit.

His steps faltered as he stumbled up the slope and he cursed loudly, drawing the attention of a bobcat doing push ups with his nose nearly touching the ground. Tanya shook her head. If any of them ever had to do farm work, they wouldn't have bothered forcing their bodies through silly, pointless exercises. Better to put their bodies to good use instead.

As nice as the outdoors was, however, her stomach still growled obnoxiously and the wily vixen thought quickly, testing an avenue for filling her empty belly. Anything was worth a shot.

"Should I really be out here?" Tanya tapped her muzzle sceptically. "What if the Church is observing the training grounds?"

Reline snorted, pacing back and forth as she hunted down the weapons she wanted to practice with that morning. The sun was low enough in the sky for it to be morning, or at least Tanya thought. She wasn't even sure where she was still.

"From where? The clouds?"

Tanya scratched the top of her head, warning off a sudden itch.

"Maybe other godlike ones can fly? How would you know?"

Reline didn't grace that with an answer and slotted a shield neatly on to her left arm. She hefted the spear in her right, levelling it as if to drive it through an imaginary target. The tip of the spear glinted in the sunlight. Inhaling deeply, she. Tanya realised she had not even stopped to change her clothing, finding her loose trousers and top adequate with the ties of her jerkin fastened securely between her breasts and down her front. They didn't impede her motion at all and she moved fluidly, lunging and retreating as she fought imaginary foes. Tanya was surprised to find herself considering what would or wouldn't be suitable attire for fighting in and shook her head, shoving the thought from her mind.

"What happened with the attack then?" Tanya boldly asked, despite Reline's indifference towards her. "No one's showed up to cart me off yet."

“We forced them back, of course. There was never any question of them launching more than a cursory attack on the keep, not with a mere hunting party. Even so, we could hold out here for many moons. There was never any true danger.”

She paused, step faltering as the spearhead tipped to the ground. She rotated her shoulder, arm circling back with a soft groan.

“No true danger for us, keeping them back from the battlements until they retreated. They thought you’d run out into their arms, thankful to be ‘saved’. They said some very strange things, all along those lines.” Reline shook her head, a troubled look in her eyes. “You could be more grateful. We saved you.”

Tanya flipped her paw up dismissively.

“I’ve heard that already. I’ll believe it when I’m no longer a prisoner here.”

“As if we are simply going to let you go. Maybe you don’t have your powers anymore but you are still an asset to us. You are very likely going to be useful. We need more useful people.”

The wolf forced the butt of the spear into the ground and pivoted around it to face Tanya, lifting her body from the ground as easily as she would swing a pup around by its paws.

Tanya remembered when she’d once done that with a visitor’s kitten, a blue-eyed mottled youngster with black, brown and white splash across its furry coat – a noble, of course, and friends with the Barreth family. When Casitha, Reline’s mother had caught her, the wolf had had the hiding of her life. Tanya warranted that there had been a red paw print on her rump for a month afterwards. The memory made her smile. It couldn’t have been that long ago. Yet it had been years. She frowned. Her memory was not to be trusted.

Reline coughed into her paw and glanced around.

“Speaking of which, you may have noticed that no one particularly cares that you’re here.”

Reline gestured, sweeping her arm wide to take in the whole of the training grounds. Tanya nodded and shrugged half-heartedly. She didn’t see much of a problem with that.

“If they knew who you were, there’d be uproar. For all the things you’ve done, they’d want your head. On a silver platter, preferably.”

Reline smiled cruelly as Tanya took a step back, paw unwittingly going to her throat. She quite liked her head exactly where it was – attached to her neck.

“Luckily, foxes aren’t exactly uncommon in these parts. And Chosen go around in this weird ceremonial dress most of the time. Without that, you’re pretty hard to identify. You’ll get by quietly as long as you don’t willingly identify yourself.”

The wolf sighed and jabbed a finger pointedly in her direction. Wenton, standing to the side, turned his eyes heavenwards.

“With that said, keep your damn gob shut about Chosen and the like, all right?” Reline blew hair out of her face, already returning her attention to training. “Don’t draw attention to yourself. You’re only out here so we can train. Nothing more than that and don’t you forget it.”

The wolf left her, devoting herself entirely to her practice session. She joined up with a small pack of wolves and ran drills, swapping spear for sword when she grew apparently bored of the tool. Either would do the job nicely in battle and she had to be proficient with either if she was to stay alive.

After some time, Wenton shifted his weight more frequently, huffing loudly as if the weight of the world rested on his shoulders.

“Were you meant to take turns watching me?” Tanya asked, ears perked.

The ox did not answer verbally but gave a long, rolling sigh. Tanya chuckled. He suddenly seemed a little more relatable and less scary, although she still wouldn’t like to find herself on the wrong side of the ox.

“You go ahead – practice.” She inclined her head gently towards the practice ground. “I’ll be here, you can keep an eye on me. I wouldn’t want to keep someone stationary when they want to be getting on and doing something.”

Wenton’s gaze slid to a deadly looking broadsword with a chunky pommel. The temptation was there. Tanya ached for a moment of solitude – admittedly in the midst of a training yard but it seemed to be the best she could manage. Just one moment without being stared at, watched as if she was going to leap up cackling, smite everyone in range and cry out that it was her plan all along.

Tanya shivered. It wasn’t a completely outlandish thing for them to suspect. She ploughed on, casting Wenton an earnest look and clasping her paws together below her breasts.

“I wouldn’t know what to do with any of this stuff anyway,” Tanya added, pursing her lips at the wooden and metal practice swords, spears, daggers and everything else an intrepid warrior may require. “I’ll stand here and watch. Though I better get some food in me soon or else my stomach is going to tear a hole through my skin and fur to get at some grub.”

He grunted and rolled his shoulders. Was there any harm? Tanya willed him to read her thoughts, imprint the notion into his skull so that he left her be, if only for a little while. Her heart fluttered anxiously against her ribcage.

“I will be watching,” he conceded at last, although there was a decidedly dubious look in his eye. “Make no mistake about that.”

Tanya rolled her eyes.

“I shan’t, don’t worry. Haven’t had anyone’s eyes off me since you dragged me in here.”

Wenton snorted.

“Didn’t we say you should be grateful about that?”

“Maybe you should show me why exactly I should be grateful then.”

The words were out before Tanya could stop them – she was making a habit of that that morning. Averting her eyes, she coughed into her paw, silently shaking as she held down her giggles. She could almost visibly see heat rising from the ox’s muzzle as his temper flared, simmering up from always burning embers.

Blessedly, however, rather than putting her back in whatever place they had decided for her, he made a non-committal noise and snatched up the broadsword he had evidently been lusting after, hefting its weight in his palm. Tanya doubted that she’d be able to lift it if it ever landed in her paws. She’d certainly have to find another way out of the keep if any hope of escape was to remain on the cards. The vixen stifled a groan. Did *everything* have to be difficult? She missed her life on the estate desperately, a growing, yawning ache in the pit of her stomach that grew the longer she was separated from it.

Keeping her in his sights, Wenton waved a big, meaty paw at a hoofed fellow as bulky as he was. A bay horse with muddied, white feather around his bare fetlocks snorted heavily and eagerly partnered up with the ox. He stood a good head and shoulders taller than the ox and Tanya winced at how much food he must require just to sustain such height and muscle mass. He would have been a nightmare to feed on the farm, that much was true.

Grateful – though not for what everyone told her she should be grateful for – for peace, Tanya drifted into thoughtlessness, simply enjoying the warmth of sun on her fur. She didn’t know how long she’d be able to stay out so she’d better make the most of it.

“You’re new here.”

A scrappy-looking lynx with a chunk out of his tufted, black ear looked Tanya up and down. He cast a wary glance at Wenton, swinging a blunt sword at a practice dummy made out of burlap sacks stuffed with straw while his training partner stood careful watch, and edged closer, shifting the weight of a crudely made sword in his left paw. Tanya swallowed but held her ground. The edge of the blade glinted. It certainly had not been dulled for practice.

“I am. What of it?”

He threw a dagger at her feet, sharpened and yet pitifully small in comparison to what he wielded. She almost laughed.

“And what do you expect me to do with this?”

She prodded it with her toe. It had a wooden handle that would no doubt sear her paw with splinters. Crude design too. The lynx scowled.

“You going to stand around? Fight me. I need someone to practice with.”

Tanya took a step back. Taking a deep breath that she was sure the lynx catalogued, just like any other trained fighter, she shook her head slowly, making the motion slow and deliberate. Where was Wenton when she actually needed him? She clearly saw Reline watching her

from the other side of the arena. The wolf returned to her practice, leaping out of the way of a feint and dodging the genuine attack from a black-furred wolf comrade with a fierce smile plastered across his muzzle. She had more immediate matters in mind. Tanya's resolve hardened.

"Hardly." Tanya made a rude gesture. "Go find someone else to bother. I wouldn't know what to do with that."

The lynx hopped from paw to paw, energy bubbling up and spilling over the edge. Tanya balked. Just what was with this cat? Had he taken leave of his senses too?

"You want another weapon? Or you scared?" The lynx bared his teeth and hissed, ears back. "We don't take in those who won't work for their keep here."

He jerked his head angrily at the dagger laying in the dirt.

"Fight me."

"No."

He settled himself back on his hind paws, legs bent like the coil of a spring.

"Be like that then, fox cub," he snarled, lip curling back from his teeth. "If you won't step up, I'll take you out. We don't look after mouths that don't work for themselves here."

He launched himself at her, paws leaving the ground as he gave a feral yowl. Tanya screamed and scrambled for the dagger, finding it in her paws a moment after she'd thought about grabbing it. But she didn't have time to think about how that had happened, or be thankful for her quick reaction. The lynx was upon her, swinging the sword as if he intended to cleave her head clean off her neck. Tanya shrieked, certain that it was all over, mind racing. There was nothing she could do – the crazy lynx was going to end her before it had even all begun!

And then something else took over the vixen. Shifting her stance so that her weight was spread evenly, she leaned to the side, letting the lynx's crazed slash fall wide of her neck. The blade slid harmlessly by and a small smile twitched at her lips. He scowled, expression darkening as he shot past, and she lunged for the dagger, scooping it up. It was a familiar, light weight in her paw and she wrapped her fingers confidently around the handle, stepping back to give herself space. Brushing her thumb over the blade, she drew a sliver of blood, smile widening.

Some part of her had missed this. Yet from when?

The lynx snarled and spat, whipping around for a second attack. Their spat was gathering attention but Tanya had no time to think about who was watching or not or even to be embarrassed for surely she would stumble on to her nose, trip over her own paws or *something*.

"Leave it," Tanya said lowly, tail as stiff as her spine. "I have no quarrel with you and want none either. I'm not going to be a good training partner for you – what experience do I have?"

Laughing, the lynx spat in the dirt.

“You dodged that one. You’ll do well enough. Prove yourself, fox, or else you’ll be out on your tail like Church scum!”

Tanya’s jaws snapped and she twisted as the lynx flung himself bodily at her, teeth flashing as his maw gaped like a black hole. Every line of his body told her that he wanted nothing more than to close his jaws around her throat. She fought back a snort, mind moving quicker with the shot of adrenaline. Time seemed to slow around her and she brought the dagger up as the lynx came down, dodging his blade and slicing the tip of hers neatly through his unscarred year. The feline screeched.

Blood dripped to the dirt. Head wounds always did bleed overly so. Holding the dagger so that the tip pointed down, Tanya circled the lynx, matching him move for move, step for step. His eyes narrowed and he swung his sword back and forth, trying to draw her eye. But Tanya could not fall for that – the other being that had taken over her mind would not allow it. Dimly she felt that she’d been in this situation before when her life actually was on the line. One lynx, in that case, would be no problem. Doubt trembled through her heart. This was not something she had learned on the farm.

Yet she was done playing games.

The lynx attacked with a half-strangled cry, holding his sword over his head with two paws. His hind paws, wrapped in strips of leather for grip, raised clouds of dust and Tanya blinked it away, eyes streaming as she moved to counter. She blocked his attack and forced her weight into the block. Strength that surprised even her pulled into muscles – larger and more functional than she remembered – and the lynx stumbled back, breaking away with a curse on his lips. His jaw hung slack, drawing in harsh gulps of air. Tanya smiled and struck. He only just blocked in time but she forced him back a few feet all the same, hind paws scudding through the dirt.

Driven to desperation, the lynx put the last shards of his energy into a wild charge, head down and sword slashing wildly. It was a brazen attempt to get past her defences and blocks but a crude one at best. Tanya smirked. She had him and the feeling made something in her heart sing.

Taking a running jump, she sprung high above the lynx’s blade, putting herself safely out of harm’s way as she brought him down. She flicked away the lynx’s sword with an almost playful bat and sent it tumbling point over pommel into the dirt where it stuck, point down. His eyes flashed with fear.

Landing on his shoulders, Tanya bore him down to the ground and, in a flash of steel, her dagger was at his throat. The lynx gasped, breath cutting off in his throat as she pressed down hard enough to draw a trickle of blood. The vixen’s bosom heaved, gasping for breath lost in the pursuit of winning the bout. Beneath her, the lynx froze, eyes bulging. The training yard around them was quiet, eerily so, and the hair on the back of her neck stood up.

Close, someone clapped slowly, bringing their paws together with deliberate precision.

“Very good, vixen.”

The leopard flicked her tail, looking down her nose at the panting Tanya on the ground. Her loose dress, not covering nearly enough, was scuffed up with dirt. The lynx growled and twisted beneath her. She sprung off him and straightened as Sellanda advanced, resting an unwelcome paw on her shoulder. Her fingers curled around, sharp nails – filed as if to mimic the claws of a beast – and dug through her fur, biting into skin. Tanya winced.

“You may be exactly what we are looking for, Tanya,” Sellanda nodded decisively. “I hope to see you at the practice yard every day from now on.”

Tanya swallowed. That was not phrased as a request or idle hope. She glanced at Wenton, standing with his nostrils flared and every muscle rigid with tension. From the middle of the training pit, blade raised as if to charge into battle, Reline glowered. Tanya cursed herself. Maybe staying inside the keep was the better idea all round. Too bad she didn’t have that option anymore.

Now, she would have to train.